

Population growth

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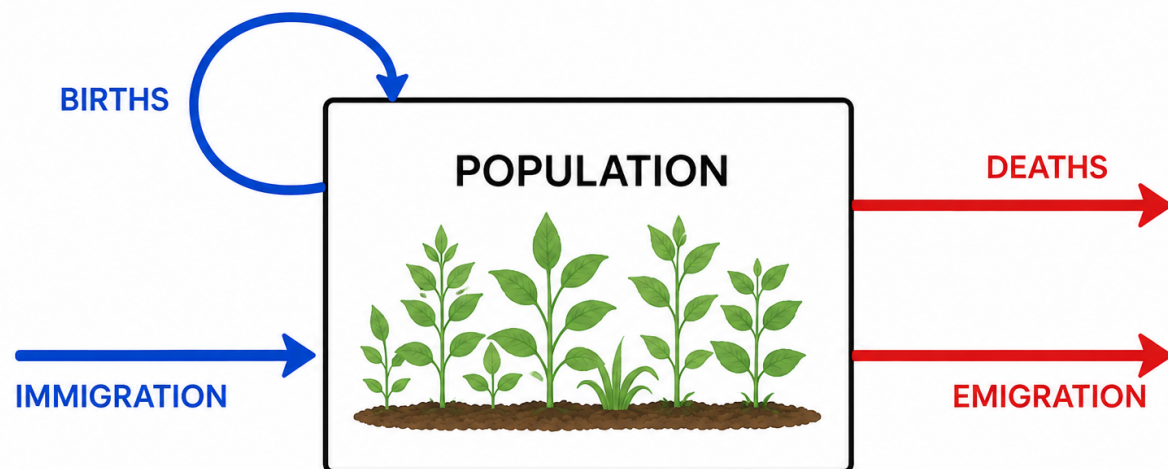
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Learning objectives

1. Understand basic processes influencing population size
2. Plot population sizes over time with different growth rates
3. Model a population with discrete and continuous time

Factors influencing population size

in most basic form, population size is determined by births, deaths, immigration, and emigration



births are a feedback loop because births are coming from the population

we are most interested in population dynamics over time

- understand causes of variation
- predict population sizes across space and time *what sort of data do we need to do this?*
- data: time series *most basic is tracking population sizes over time*

model depends on how we are measuring time

Terminology and variables in population models

- discrete time - divide into time steps (e.g. year), difference equation
- continuous time - differential equation

we'll mostly work with discrete time

relate to Kezia's statistics class- geometric distribution for discrete response variables, exponential distribution for continuous response variables, but very similar

- N = population size
- t = time
- per capita = per individual
- N_t = population at t

N_{t+1} is size in next year

- λ = per capita growth rate (discrete, geometric)
- dN/dt = rate of change in population size
- r = intrinsic growth rate (continuous, exponential)

Models

Discrete time with geometric growth

$$N_{t+1} = \lambda N_t$$

- $\lambda = 1$, population growth is constant
- $\lambda < 1$, population decline
- $\lambda > 1$, population growth

we can rearrange this equation so we get population at any t

$$N_T = N_0 \lambda^T$$

N_0 is initial population size

*with that exponent, looks more like unrestricted growth like what we would expect
draw t vs. N as points*

Continuous time with exponential growth

$$\frac{dN}{dt} = rN(t)$$

- $r = 0$, change in population size is 0
- $-r$, population decline
- $+r$, population growth

$$N(T) = N(0)e^{rT}$$

draw t vs. N as continuous line

*in real populations, births, deaths, immigration, emigration aren't constant
so population sizes over time aren't nice continuous*

Demographic stochasticity

- variation due to chance events affecting individuals
- birth/death rates in diagram are an average
- model: per capita growth rate comes from a distribution *e.g. lambda is uniform distribution between 0.5 and 1.5*
- increases extinction risk in small populations *because if by chance reproductive individuals have few offspring for a few years, population could go extinct*

Geometric vs. arithmetic growth

given that lambda fluctuates year to year, what if you wanted to get the average population growth rate?

lambda is per capita population growth rate, so we need average lambda

exponential-looking relationship makes it confusing when we're trying to get population growth rate

- average population growth rate = $\text{mean}(\text{LOG}(\lambda))$
- geometric mean
- $\log(\text{mean}(\lambda)) = \text{arithmetic mean}$ *can overestimate population growth*